The Han Dynasty

Under Emperor Gaozu, the Han Dynasty made great strides in advancing culture, society and technology. China began trading with western civilizations and new technologies were discovered. While the Zhou Dynasty was the first to produce a written history of the country, the First Emperor had destroyed vast libraries of literature. Historians generally agree that the Han Dynasty was the first to write histories since none existed at the time. The famous *Canon of Medicine* was compiled and became the first written medical text to emerge in Chinese history. While gunpowder had been introduced to the country long before, it was developed further during the Han Dynasty. The Chinese also produced paper and advanced writing utensils. The government established Confucianism as the main philosophy for everyone and it became so widespread that it is still used today to influence decisions made by the government. In contrast to the First Emperor, Gaozu did not ban other ideologies. This ultimately caused advancements in education and literature. Men were released from military duties because the country was not in a state of warfare like it had been before.

When the emperor died in 195 BCE, his son Liu Ying took the throne and continued on with his father's policies. The country enjoyed a long period of stability. Out of all the Han emperors, it was Wu Ti who took the country through one of the greatest moments in history. During Wu Ti's rule the borders were expanded, public buildings were created and new inventions were made. In 138 CE, he sent Zhang Qian west to build trade routes and the Silk Road was finished eight years later. Confucianism was taught in schools as part the government curriculum. Transportation and trading networks were improved, the economy grew and thousands of people were able to gain employment.